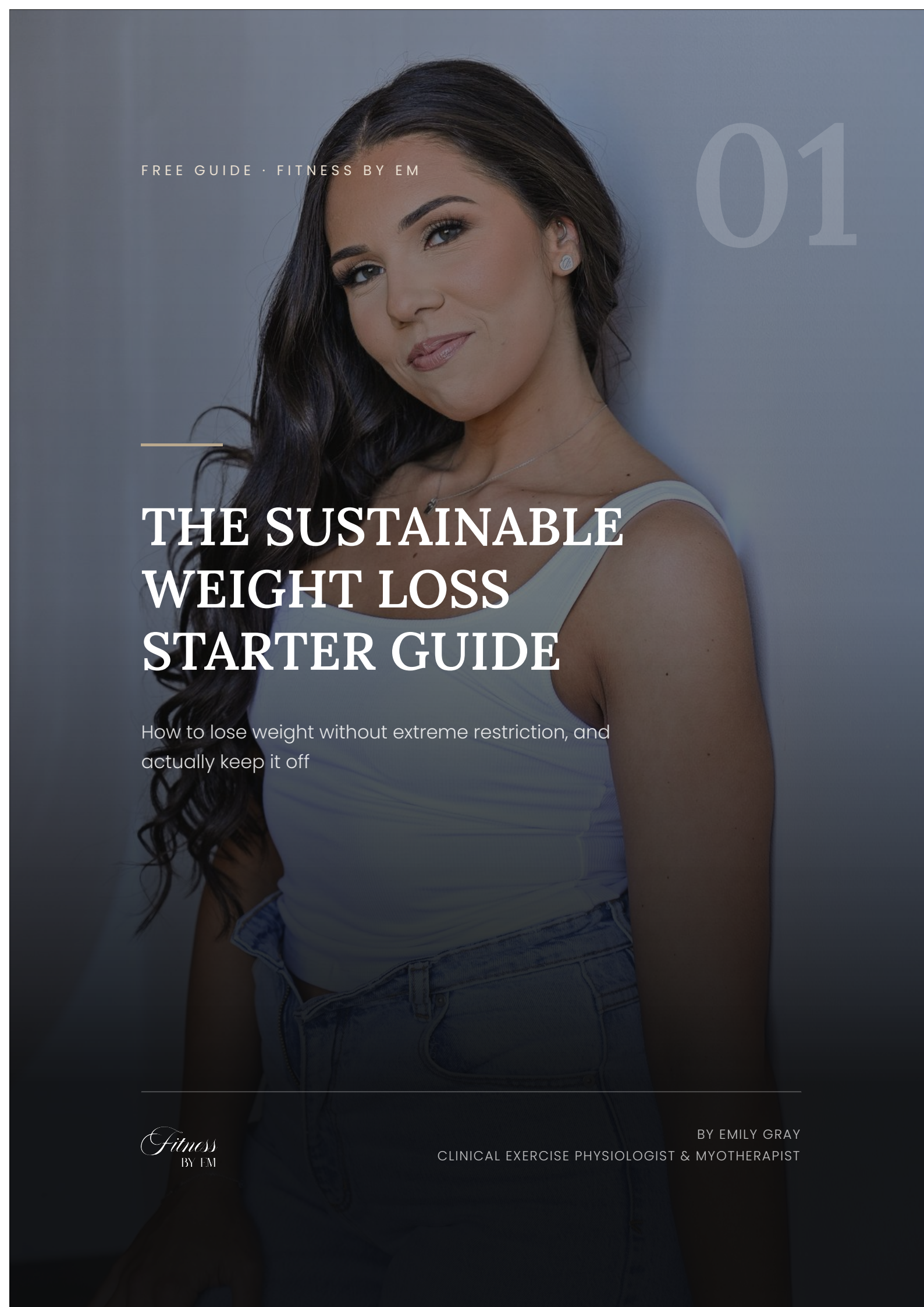


FREE GUIDE · FITNESS BY EM

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THE SUSTAINABLE WEIGHT LOSS STARTER GUIDE

How to lose weight without extreme restriction, and actually keep it off

Fitness BY EM

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THE SUSTAINABLE WEIGHT LOSS STARTER GUIDE

How to lose weight without extreme restriction, and actually keep it off



15-25%	0.25-0.75kg	450+
SUSTAINABLE DEFICIT	FAT LOSS PER WEEK	WOMEN COACHED

Introduction

If you've picked this up, you've probably already tried the 1200-calorie diet, the 21-day reset, the influencer meal plan, maybe all three. You lost some weight. Then life happened, the restriction stopped feeling sustainable, and it came back. Possibly with a little extra alongside it.

That's not a willpower problem. That's a program problem.

This guide is the starting point I give clients before we ever build a personalised plan together. It won't give you a magic number or a 30-day miracle. What it will give you is the actual framework, calorie targets, protein, training, and mindset, that makes weight loss sustainable instead of another cycle you're stuck in.

Everything here is grounded in exercise physiology, not trends. Let's start.

1. Why Most Weight Loss Attempts Fail

Before we get into what works, it's worth understanding why the things you've already tried probably didn't.

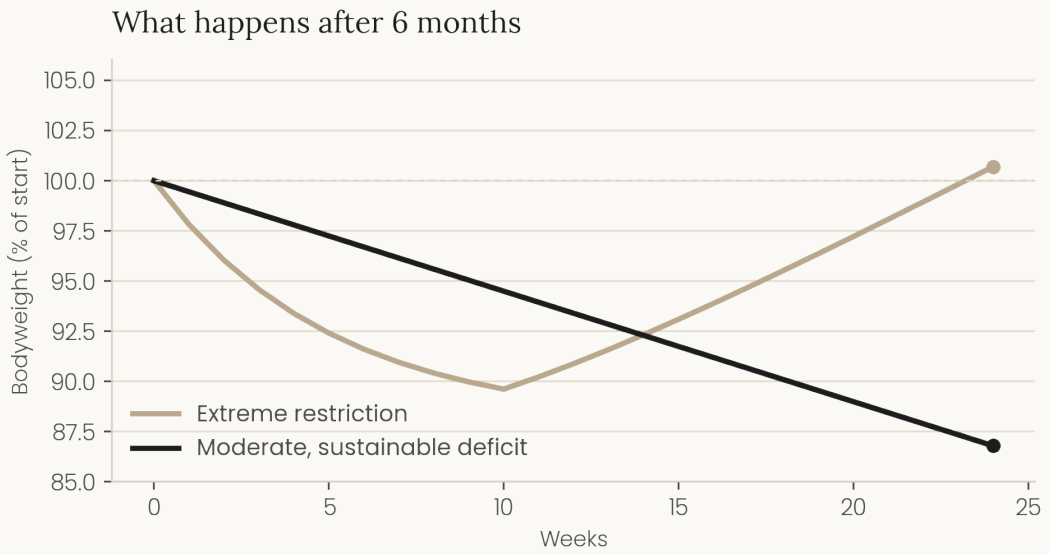
Extreme calorie deficits work, briefly. Cutting your intake dramatically produces fast results because you're in a large energy deficit. But your body is built to resist that. When you under-eat significantly for a sustained period, several things happen: your metabolism adapts downward to conserve energy, hunger hormones like ghrelin increase, satiety hormones like leptin decrease, and your energy for training and daily life drops. Eventually the restriction becomes unbearable, and most people rebound, often eating more than they would have if they'd never restricted so hard in the first place.

Generic plans ignore your actual life. A meal plan built for a hypothetical person with no social calendar, no cravings, and unlimited meal prep time doesn't survive contact with a real week. If a plan doesn't account for the dinner out, the tired Tuesday, or the fact that you don't love steamed broccoli, it was never going to last.

Training and nutrition are treated as separate problems. Most diets focus purely on food and ignore that muscle is metabolically active tissue that shapes your body composition and your resting metabolic rate. Weight loss without strength training tends to cost you muscle along with fat, which is part of why the scale can drop while you don't actually look or feel different.

The goal is set is too far in the future. "Lose 20kg" is not a plan, it's a hope. Without a structure for the weeks in between, motivation is the only thing holding it together, and motivation is unreliable by design.

The fix for all four of these isn't more willpower. It's a different system.



Illustrative example: an extreme deficit produces faster early loss but tends to rebound. A moderate deficit is slower but holds.

2. Setting A Realistic Calorie Target

Weight loss, at its core, requires a calorie deficit, burning more energy than you consume. That part of the equation is genuinely simple. Where people go wrong is in how aggressive that deficit is and how long they try to sustain it.

A sustainable deficit is typically 15-25% below your maintenance calories (the amount you burn in a day at your current weight and activity level). This produces a realistic, healthy rate of fat loss of roughly 0.25-0.75kg per week, and it's small enough that your body doesn't panic and start fighting you for it.

> *A sustainable deficit is 15-25% below maintenance, producing 0.25-0.75kg of fat loss per week. Slower and sustainable beats fast and abandoned, every time.*

Roughly estimating your starting point:

To get a rough daily maintenance calorie estimate, multiply your bodyweight in kg by 22-26, adjusting up if you're very active and down if you're largely sedentary. This is a starting estimate, not a prescription, everybody's metabolism varies, which is exactly why tracking your results over the first two to three weeks and adjusting is more accurate than any formula.

From there, a deficit of 300-500 calories per day below that estimate is a sensible starting point for most women. That's the difference between a large deficit that leaves you exhausted and irritable, and one you can actually live inside for months.

Signs your deficit is too aggressive: constant hunger, disrupted sleep, irritability, missed periods or cycle changes, dizziness, declining gym performance, obsessive thoughts about food. If you're experiencing several of these, the fix isn't to push through, it's to eat more and lose slightly slower. Slower and sustainable beats fast and abandoned every time.

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3. Why Protein Is The Most Important Variable

If there's one nutrition lever that matters more than any other for women losing weight, it's protein.

Protein does three things that directly support fat loss:

It preserves muscle mass while you're in a calorie deficit, meaning more of the weight you lose comes from fat rather than lean tissue. This is what separates people who lose weight and look leaner and more defined from people who lose weight and just look smaller.

It's the most satiating macronutrient, meaning it keeps you fuller for longer per calorie than carbohydrates or fat. This directly reduces the hunger that derails most diets.

It has a higher thermic effect than other macronutrients, meaning your body burns more energy digesting and processing it.

A practical target for most women in a fat loss phase is roughly 1.6-2.2 grams of protein per kilogram of bodyweight per day, or more simply, aiming for 25-40 grams of protein at each main meal. You don't need to hit this with surgical precision every single day. Getting close, consistently, matters far more than perfect tracking.

Easy ways to increase protein without overhauling your diet: add a protein source to breakfast (Greek yoghurt, eggs, a protein shake), choose leaner cuts of meat and larger portions of it, add legumes or tofu to meals that are currently carb-heavy, and keep a high-protein snack on hand (cottage cheese, jerky, protein bars) for the moments you'd otherwise reach for something less filling.

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4. The Training Approach That Supports Fat Loss Best

Cardio alone is not the most effective tool for sustainable fat loss, even though it's usually the first thing people reach for. Resistance training deserves the priority position in your week, for a simple reason: it's the primary signal that tells your body to hold onto (or build) muscle while you're losing weight, which is what determines whether the number on the scale translates into visible, lasting change.

A sustainable structure for most women:

Two to four resistance training sessions per week, focused on compound movements (squats, hinges, presses, rows, pulls) that train multiple muscle groups at once and give you the most return for your time.

Progressive overload as the driver of results, gradually increasing weight, reps, or sets over time rather than doing the same workout indefinitely. Your body only changes when it's given a reason to.

Movement outside the gym (walking is the simplest and most underrated tool here) to increase your daily energy expenditure without adding fatigue that compromises your training or recovery.

Optional, additional cardio, layered in based on preference and recovery capacity, not as a punishment for what you ate.

You do not need to train for two hours a day or do a workout you dread to lose weight sustainably. Two to four well-structured sessions a week, done consistently over months, will outperform an unsustainable seven-day routine that burns you out by week three.

5. What To Do When The Scale Doesn'T Move

Every sustainable weight loss journey includes weeks where the scale doesn't move, or even ticks up slightly. This is normal, and it doesn't mean the process has failed.

Things that affect the scale that have nothing to do with fat loss: water retention from a harder training session, more carbohydrates or sodium than usual, hormonal fluctuations across your menstrual cycle, stress, sleep quality, and simply how much food is currently in your digestive system. Your bodyweight can fluctuate by one to two kilograms day to day for entirely normal reasons.

What to actually track instead of daily weight: a weekly average of your bodyweight (rather than any single reading), how your clothes fit, progress photos taken in consistent lighting and clothing every two to four weeks, your energy levels, and your strength in the gym.

If your weekly average genuinely plateaus for three to four consecutive weeks despite consistent effort, that's when it's worth reassessing your calorie target, your activity level may have quietly increased, or your maintenance calories may have shifted as your bodyweight has changed. A small further adjustment, not a dramatic overhaul, is usually all that's needed.

6. How To Lose Weight Without Giving Up Your Social Life

A plan that can't survive a dinner out, a birthday, or a holiday isn't a plan, it's a countdown to the next time you "start again on Monday."

A few practical strategies:

Build flexibility into your weekly structure rather than your daily one. If you're tracking, think in terms of a weekly calorie average rather than a rigid daily number, this gives you room to enjoy a bigger meal out without derailing the whole week.

Eat protein and vegetables first at social meals, this fills you up on the most satiating options before you get to the parts of the meal you have less control over.

Don't "save up" by starving yourself before an event. This almost always backfires into overeating once you arrive, because you're arriving both under-fuelled and mentally primed to make up for lost time.

Alcohol, if you drink, is worth being mindful of rather than eliminating entirely for most people, it's easier to sustain a plan that allows a drink at the occasional event than one that demands total abstinence and creates a sense of deprivation.

The goal was never to remove yourself from your life in order to lose weight. It's to build a version of eating and training that fits inside the life you already have.

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7. The Mindset Shift That Makes Everything Easier

The single biggest shift I see in clients who go on to keep their results long-term is this: they stop treating weight loss as a project with an end date, and start treating it as a set of habits they're building for good.

"I'm on a diet" implies an endpoint, a return to how you ate before once the goal is hit. That mental model is exactly what drives the yo-yo pattern so many women get stuck in.

The more useful frame is: "I'm building a way of eating and training I can actually live inside." That reframe changes the decisions you make day to day. It means not choosing the most extreme, fastest option, because you're not trying to survive twelve weeks, you're building something you'll still be doing in twelve months.

It also means being patient with imperfect weeks. One inconsistent day, or even an inconsistent week, doesn't undo progress. What derails people isn't the missed workout or the bigger meal, it's the all-or-nothing thinking that turns one off-plan moment into a week, then a month, of giving up entirely. Progress isn't a straight line, and it was never supposed to be.



Emily Gray

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READY FOR MORE?

Work with Emily 1:1

This guide gives you the framework. What it can't give you is the personalisation, the exact calorie target for your body, a training program built around your schedule and experience level, and someone checking in when motivation dips and life gets busy, which it will.

That's exactly what coaching is for.

If you'd like to talk through where you're at and what a personalised plan could look like, book a free 30-minute call. No pressure, no sales script, just an honest conversation about your goals and whether working together makes sense.

Book a free call: calendly.com/emilygray81099/free-30min-consult-call
Instagram: instagram.com/_fitnessbyem_
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